

Routine blood tests

Bloodwork will be collected to determine your blood type and tested for anemia and various infections, such as HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B. Detecting and treating infections early can prevent or greatly reduce the risk of transmission to your baby.

Complete blood count This is a screening for anemia, which occurs most commonly from low levels of iron in the blood. If you're anemic, you'll be advised to eat [iron-rich foods](#) and may need an iron supplement.

Blood type A blood test will determine your blood type (A, B, O, or AB) and if you're rhesus positive (Rh+) or [rhesus negative \(Rh-\)](#). During pregnancy and at the birth, a small number of fetal red blood cells may cross the placenta into maternal circulation. This happens most commonly during the birthing process or if you have any bleeding in pregnancy.. If you are Rh- and your baby is Rh+, your body will develop antibodies to destroy the fetal cells in your circulation. This is known as sensitization. These antibodies in turn can cross to the placenta, destroying the baby's cells and causing anemia. This is unlikely to be problematic in a first pregnancy, but may get more severe with each subsequent pregnancy.

To prevent this from happening, you will be given an anti-D injection during pregnancy at about 28 weeks. After delivery your baby's blood type will be checked and, if confirmed to be Rh+, you will be given another dose of anti-D. If you have any bleeding in pregnancy or after an amniocentesis, you may also need an anti-D injection.

There is a new test becoming available to check the baby's Rh status. Tiny fragments of the baby's blood in your circulation can be tested to determine whether your baby is Rh+ or Rh-. If your baby is negative, you won't need anti-D.

Rubella This blood test checks your immunity to rubella. Infection with rubella in early pregnancy may cause serious problems for the baby. If you aren't immune, you can't be vaccinated in pregnancy, but will usually be vaccinated after delivery so you're protected in future pregnancies.

Hepatitis B This test identifies women who are infected with hepatitis B, a viral liver disease that can be transmitted to the baby.

Syphilis The blood test checks if you have ever had syphilis. Active syphilis can cross the placenta and cause serious complications in your baby.

HIV You will be offered a test for human immunodeficiency virus (HIV). If you have HIV, you can reduce the chances of passing this on to your baby by taking antiviral agents and not breast-feeding.